

Happy landings

A clouded yellow butterfly comes in to land on a thistle. Butterfly flight is more controlled than it looks. The insect is able to change course instantly and make sudden landings.

Butterflies feed through a tube called a proboscis. This is coiled up when not in use.



Butterflies have clubbed antennae.

2. The butterfly must stay still for many hours, as blood is pumped into the wing veins to stretch the wings. Later it holds its wings apart to let them harden.



In the background

Some butterflies make a tasty meal for birds. But if they are able to blend in with their background, they may avoid being eaten. The open wings of the Indian leaf

butterfly have a striking orange pattern. But when its wings are closed, the butterfly looks exactly like an old, dry leaf.



Wings open.

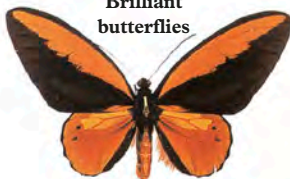
Wings closed, resting on leaf.



3. When its wings have hardened, the butterfly is ready to fly off to find its first meal of nectar.



Brilliant butterflies



Wallace's golden birdwing



Glass swallowtail butterfly



88 butterfly



Cramer's blue morpho butterfly

Scaly wings

The wings of both butterflies and moths are covered with tiny scales, which overlap like the tiles on a roof. Bright colors can either be used to attract a mate, or to warn predators that the butterfly, or moth, is not good to eat.